

Big Muddy Touring — 12-Month Plan

Written 2026-04-29. Voice: admin documentation. Numbers from THE_THESIS, not aspirational.

What it is

A booking and tour-support operation along the Mississippi corridor and the Blues Highway, anchored in Natchez. Built first to support Amy's career as Arrie Aslin, then opened to other touring acts who need routing, lodging, transport, and promotion through the Big Muddy media stack.

What's working today

- **Amy performs publicly as Arrie Aslin** — artist-in-residence at the Inn and the first artist on the Big Muddy Records roster. Real shows, real audience, weekly cadence.
- **The Big Muddy Inn provides lodging** for visiting acts. That's a legitimate cost advantage no other booking operation in this corridor has.
- **The Blues Room** at the Inn is a working venue. Capacity is small (listening-room scale, not a 500-cap club), but it's a reliable second-night stop for any act routing through.
- **The Sprinter van** is operational this week (per CLAUDE.md). That's tour transport for short corridor runs without renting per-trip.
- **bigmuddytouring.com is live.** Booking inquiries route through the site.
- **Big Muddy Radio + Magazine give us an in-house promotion engine.** Acts get airplay and editorial coverage for being on a Big Muddy bill — that's the trade.
- **Big Muddy Records exists as a label entity.** Catalog is small (Arrie Aslin, plus selected previously-released material — Amy Allen, Scruggs). The label is real, the artist roster is curated, not aspirational.

What is NOT working yet: a published show calendar, a routing playbook for non-Amy acts, a deal sheet template, and a clean booking inquiry flow. All listed below.

The economics

Revenue model

- Booking fees on shows we route through the corridor (% of door or flat per-night fee)
- Door splits on Blues Room shows
- Inn room nights generated by touring acts (this revenue books to the Inn, not to Touring, but it's a real ecosystem dollar)
- Merchandise margin on co-branded runs (TBD — not active yet)
- Sponsor / brand packages bundled with show calendars (TBD)

Cost structure

- Sprinter van: insurance, fuel, maintenance. Annual figure TBD; pull from operating bills before Tuesday.
- Booking labor: currently absorbed by Chase + Tracy + Amy. No dedicated booker on payroll. The shows-and-programming role is in conversation but not finalized — not named publicly.
- Promotion: covered by the in-house Magazine + Radio + social channels. Marginal cash cost.
- Show-specific costs (sound tech, security on bigger nights) billed per-show, not as fixed overhead.

Current revenue

- Per-show. No standing run rate yet. Booking history and door splits live in Tracy's records — pull a real number before Tuesday. **TBD until then.**

12-month target

- Per THE_THESIS, Touring is **not measured as an agency P&L**. The success metric is: Amy plays + other bands tour + the corridor music economy lifts.
- Honest dollar contribution to the ecosystem in Y1: **15k–40k**, mostly from booking fees and door splits, plus uncounted upside in Inn room nights generated.
- If the corridor circuit fills, the upside is larger; if it stalls, the floor is Amy's residency at the Blues Room, which we control.

The customer

Who books

- Touring artists routing the Blues Highway (Memphis → Clarksdale → Natchez → New Orleans)
- Mississippi-resident acts looking for Natchez dates
- Festival routing (Crescent City Blues, Juke Joint, King Biscuit) who want a side date
- Wedding clients booking Arrie Aslin or the Big Muddy house band for private events

- Brand sponsors looking to attach to the Blues Room or a corridor run

Who pays

- Booking client (the act or their agent) for routing/transport/lodging packages
- Venues for talent buying (when Big Muddy Touring acts as a buyer's agent)
- Door takes split per-show
- Sponsor brands paying to attach (when active)

Named prospects we already know

- Arrie Aslin (Amy) — anchor. Confirmed.
 - The catalog under Big Muddy Records (Amy Allen / Scruggs back catalog) — releases we can promote without booking new sessions.
 - Regina Charboneau / Biscuits & Blues — venue partner with overlapping audience.
 - Visit Natchez — CVB conversations open; Touring is one of the things they want to talk about.
 - Mississippi Blues Trail / state tourism — partnership conversations TBD.
 - A short list of corridor venues already in conversation (specifics TBD; Tracy and Chase enumerate before Tuesday).
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The 12-month plan

Q1 (May–Jul 2026) — get the operating system in place

- Publish the Blues Room weekly calendar. Arrie Aslin anchors at least one night/week. Two additional touring acts/week minimum.
- Build the booking inquiry flow on bigmuddytouring.com. One form, one inbox, one response template.
- Write the corridor routing playbook: which venues, which nights, what each pays, what each costs.
- Sprinter van: log every mile, every fuel stop. Set a real per-mile cost number by end of Q1.
- Sign 3 outside touring acts to a Big Muddy corridor run.

Q2 (Aug–Oct 2026) — push the corridor

- 6–10 outside acts routed through. Each one stays at the Inn (room-night revenue books to Inn).
- One festival side-date deal (Crescent City Blues or King Biscuit weekend).
- First Big Muddy Records release of the year: a single from Arrie Aslin or a re-released catalog track. Promoted through Magazine + Radio.

- Wedding/private event bookings: target 4–6 Arrie Aslin or Big Muddy house band dates.

Q3 (Nov 2026–Jan 2027) — record + radio + holiday

- Holiday programming at the Blues Room: ticketed shows Thanksgiving + NYE.
- Big Muddy Records: second release. Goal is two singles + one EP across the year.
- Big Muddy Radio: lock the regular show schedule. Use it to promote upcoming Blues Room dates and corridor runs.
- January: light booking month. Use the down time to plan Q4 spring corridor + summer festival routing.

Q4 (Feb–Apr 2027) — book the spring corridor

- 8–12 outside acts on the calendar.
 - One Arrie Aslin tour run — 4 to 7 dates, corridor-only, Sprinter-supported.
 - Year-end review: did Touring lift the corridor economy? Did it lift the Inn? Did it lift Records? Where did the dollars actually land?
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What we need to make it happen

Capital

- No new capital required for the operating plan. Sprinter van is here. Inn is operational. Records label exists.
- One-time: ~\$1,500 for a printed routing playbook + booking deal sheet templates.

Hires

- None on payroll. The shows-and-programming role is in conversation but not finalized; we will not name a person on outward-facing copy until the deal is signed.
- Studio C handles content production (concert documentation, social cuts) under their \$1k/mo retainer.

Decisions Chase needs from Tracy + Amy

- Confirm Blues Room weekly cadence (Amy as anchor — yes/no, what nights).
- Approve the Sprinter van usage policy: who drives, when, who pays for fuel out of which bucket.
- Approve the booking deal sheet template before it goes out.
- Set Amy's tolerance for solo + co-bill performance frequency. The ceiling rule applies here too.

Dependencies

- Sprinter van insured and DOT-compliant for any out-of-state runs (verify).
 - bigmuddytouring.com booking form posts to a real inbox someone reads daily.
 - Big Muddy Records distribution agreement live for any new release (confirm via DistroKid or equivalent).
 - Magazine editorial calendar locked one quarter ahead so corridor announcements fire with the right lead time.
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The risk

- **The corridor doesn't fill.** Mitigation: Amy's residency at the Blues Room is a controlled floor. We are not dependent on outside acts to make any single week work.
 - **Sprinter van breakdown on a tour run.** Insurance + AAA cover the dollars; the bigger risk is a missed show. Mitigation: only route corridor dates Sprinter can reach with a margin for failure (no 14-hour single-day drives).
 - **A booked act cancels last-minute.** Standard touring risk. Booking deal sheet must include a cancellation clause.
 - **Amy burns out** — same risk as the Inn plan. Same ceiling rule. Tracy and Amy decide.
 - **Records release flops.** Pre-revenue Y1 is acceptable per THE_THESIS. The point is the artist roster, not chart position.
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Why it matters to the ecosystem

- Touring is the **engine that fills the Inn** outside of leisure-tourism weeks. Every routed act = room nights + Blues Room door + bar revenue.
- It's the **content engine for Magazine and Radio.** Every show is a story, an interview, a track to spin. Without Touring, the editorial calendar gets thin fast.
- It's the **catalog engine for Records.** Acts that route through the corridor become candidates for the label.
- It's the **proof of the corridor thesis.** If we can route 12+ outside acts in a year and they keep coming back, the Mississippi corridor is real and the rest of the ecosystem has a story to tell.
- It's the place **Amy gets to actually be the artist she is.** That alone is enough reason for the brand to exist; the corridor revenue is the upside.

If Touring works, the Inn fills, the Magazine has subjects, the Records catalog grows, and the corridor's music economy gets a measurable lift. If Touring doesn't work, Amy still plays the Blues Room weekly and we adjust.

End of plan. Next step: Chase and Tracy enumerate the named corridor venues + pull the trailing 12-month booking revenue number before Tuesday's call.